

‘That is the march of great minds and things, my lord.’

‘Even the longing for the tiara?’

‘To be pope is to be the first of Christians. Why should you not desire that?’

‘It has been printed that, to gain that object, I had sold Cambria to the Spaniards.’

‘You have, perhaps, yourself written pamphlets without severely persecuting pamphleteers.’

‘Then, reverend father, I have truly a clean breast. I feel nothing remaining but slight peccadilloes.’

‘What are they?’

‘Play.’

‘That is rather worldly: but you were obliged by the duties of greatness to keep a good house.’

‘I like to win.’

‘No player plays to lose.’

‘I cheated a little.’

‘You took your advantage. Pass on.’

‘Well! reverend father, I feel nothing else upon my conscience. Give me absolution, and my soul will be able, when God shall please to call it, to mount without obstacle to the throne—’

The Theatin moved neither his arms nor his lips. ‘What are you waiting for, father?’ said Mazarin.

‘I am waiting for the end.’

‘The end of what?’

‘Of the confession, monsieur.’

‘But I have ended.’

‘Oh, no; your eminence is mistaken.’

‘Not that I know of.’

‘Search diligently.’

‘I have searched as well as possible.’

‘Then I shall assist your memory.’

‘Do.’

The Theatin coughed several times. ‘You have said nothing of avarice, another capital sin, nor of those millions,’ said he.

‘What millions, father?’

‘Why, those you possess, my lord.’

‘Father, that money is mine, why should I speak to you about that?’

‘Because, you see, our opinions differ. You say that money is yours, whilst I—I believe it is rather the property of others.’

Mazarin lifted his cold hand to his brow, which was beaded with perspiration. ‘How so?’ stammered he.

‘This way. Your excellency had gained much wealth—in the service of the king.’

‘Hum! much—that is, not too much.’

‘Whatever it may be, whence came that wealth?’

‘From the state.’

‘The state; that is the king.’

‘But what do you conclude from that, father?’ said Mazarin, who began to tremble.

‘I cannot conclude without seeing a list of the riches you possess. Let us reckon a little, if you please. You have the bishopric of Metz?’

‘Yes.’

‘The Abbays of St Clement, St Arnould, and St Vincent, all at Metz?’

‘Yes.’

‘You have the Abbey of St Denis, in France, magnificent property?’

‘Yes, father.’

‘You have the Abbey of Cluny, which is rich?’

‘I have.’

‘That of St Medard at Soissons, with a revenue of one hundred thousand livres?’

‘I cannot deny it.’

‘That of St Victor, at Marseilles,—one of the best in the south?’

‘Yes father.’

‘A good million a year. With the emoluments of the cardinalship and the ministry, I say too little when I say two millions a year.’

‘Eh!’

‘In ten years that is twenty millions—and twenty millions put out at fifty per cent. give, by progression, twenty-three millions in ten years.’

‘How well you reckon for a Theatin!’

‘Since your eminence placed our order in the convent we occupy, near St Germain des Pres, in 1644, I have kept the accounts of the society.’

‘And mine likewise, apparently, father.’

‘One ought to know a little of everything, my lord.’

‘Very well. Conclude, at present.’

‘I conclude that your baggage is too heavy to allow you to pass through the gates of Paradise.’

‘Shall I be damned?’

‘If you do not make restitution, yes.’

Mazarin uttered a piteous cry. ‘Restitution!—but to whom, good God?’

‘To the owner of that money,—to the king.’

‘But the king did not give it all to me.’

‘One moment,—does not the king sign the ordinances?’

Mazarin passed from sighs to groans. ‘Absolution! absolution!’ cried he.

‘Impossible, my lord. Restitution! restitution!’ replied the Theatin.

‘But you absolve me from all other sins, why not from that?’

‘Because,’ replied the father, ‘to absolve you for that motive would be a sin for which the king would never absolve me, my lord.’

Thereupon the confessor quitted his penitent with an air full of compunction. He then went out in the same manner he had entered.

‘Oh, good God!’ groaned the cardinal. ‘Come here, Colbert, I am very, very ill indeed, my friend.’

‘I see no sin in being able to ride well on horseback,’ said the Theatin; ‘that is in perfect good taste, and does honour to our gown. As a Christian, I approve of your having prevented the effusion of blood; as a monk, I am proud of the bravery a monk has exhibited.’

Mazarin bowed his head humbly. ‘Yes,’ said he, ‘but the consequences?’

‘What consequences?’

‘Eh! that damned sin of pride has roots without end. From the time that I threw myself in that manner between two armies, that I had smelt powder and faced lines of soldiers, I have held generals a little in contempt.’

‘Ah!’ said the father.

‘There is the evil; so that I have not found one endurable since that time.’

‘The fact is,’ said the Theatin, ‘that the generals we have had have not been remarkable.’

‘Oh!’ cried Mazarin, ‘there was Monsieur le Prince. I have tormented him thoroughly!’

‘He is not much to be pitied: he has acquired sufficient glory, and sufficient wealth.’

‘That may be, for Monsieur le Prince; but M. Beaufort, for example—whom I held suffering so long in the dungeon of Vincennes?’

‘Ah! but he was a rebel, and the safety of the state required that you should make a sacrifice. Pass on!’

‘I believe I have exhausted pride. There is another sin which I am afraid to qualify.’

‘I can qualify it myself. Tell it.’

‘A great sin, reverend father!’

‘We shall judge, monseigneur.’

‘You cannot fail to have heard of certain relations which I have had—with her majesty the queen-mother;—the malevolent—’

‘The malevolent, my lord, are fools. Was it not necessary for the good of the state and the interests of the young king, that you should live in good intelligence with the queen? Pass on, pass on!’

‘I assure you,’ said Mazarin, ‘you remove a terrible weight from my breast.’

‘These are all trifles!—look for something serious.’

‘I have had much ambition, father.’

‘Sinners?’ replied Mazarin. ‘Do you use that word ironically, and to reproach me with all the genealogies I have allowed to be made on my account—I—the son of a fisherman, in fact?’¹

‘Hum!’ said the Theatin.

‘That is a first sin, father; for I have allowed myself made to descend from two old Roman consuls, S. Geganius Macerinus 1st, Macerinus 2d, and Proculus Macerinus 3d, of whom the Chronicle of Haolander speaks. From Macerinus to Mazarin the proximity was tempting. Macerinus, a diminutive, means leanish, poorish, out of case. Oh! reverend father! Mazarini may now be carried to the augmentative Maigre, thin as Lazarus. Look!’—and he showed his fleshless arms.

‘In your having been born of a family of fishermen I see nothing injurious to you; for—St Peter was a fisherman; and if you are a prince of the church, my lord, he was the supreme head of it. Pass on, if you please.’

‘So much the more for my having threatened with the Basille a certain Bounet, a priest of Avignon, who wanted to publish a genealogy of the Casa Mazarini much too marvellous.’

‘To be probable?’ replied the Theatin.

‘Oh! if I had acted up to his idea, father, that would have been the vice of pride—another sin.’

‘It was an excess of wit, and a person is not to be reproached with such sorts of abuses. Pass on, pass on!’

‘I was all pride. Look you, father, I will endeavour to divide that into capital sins.’

‘I like divisions, when well made.’

‘I am glad of that. You must know that in 1630—alas! that is thirty-one years ago—’

‘You were then twenty-nine years old, monseigneur.’

‘A hot-headed age. I was then something of a soldier, and I threw myself at Casal into the arquebuses, to show that I rode on horseback as well as an officer. It is true, I restored peace between the French and the Spaniards. That redeems my sin a little.’

¹This is quite untranslatable—it being a play upon the words *pêcheur* (with a grave over the first e), a sinner, and *pêcheur* (with an accent circumflex over the first e), a fisherman.—TRANS.

Chapter XLVI

The Donation



COLBERT reappeared beneath the curtains.

‘Have you heard?’ said Mazarin.

‘Alas! yes, my lord.’

‘Can he be right? Can all this money be badly acquired?’

‘A Theatin, monseigneur, is a bad judge in matters of finance,’ replied Colbert, coolly. ‘And yet it is very possible that, according to his theological views, your eminence has been, in a certain degree, in the wrong. People generally find they have been so,—when they die.’

‘In the first place, they commit the wrong of dying, Colbert.’

‘That is true, my lord. Against whom, however, did the Theatin make out that you had committed these wrongs? Against the king?’

Mazarin shrugged his shoulders. ‘As if I had not saved both his state and his finances.’

‘That admits of no contradiction, my lord.’

‘Does it? Then I have received a merely legitimate salary, in spite of the opinion of my confessor?’

‘That is beyond doubt.’

‘And I might fairly keep for my own family, which is so needy, a good fortune,—the whole, even, of which I have earned?’

‘I see no impediment to that, monseigneur.’

‘I felt assured that in consulting you, Colbert, I should have good advice,’ replied Mazarin, greatly delighted.

Colbert resumed his pedantic look. ‘My lord,’ interrupted he, ‘I think it would be quite as well to examine whether what the Theatin said is not a snare.’

‘Oh! no; a snare? What for? The Theatin is an honest man.’

‘He believed your eminence to be at death’s door, because your eminence consulted him. Did I not hear him say—“Distinguish that which the king has given you from that which you have given yourself.” Recollect, my lord, if he did not say something a little like that to you?—that is quite a theatrical speech.’

‘That is possible.’

‘In which case, my lord, I should consider you as required by the Theatin to—’

‘To make restitution!’ cried Mazarin, with great warmth.

‘Eh! I do not say no.’

‘What, of all! You do not dream of such a thing! You speak just as the confessor did.’

‘To make restitution of a part,—that is to say, his majesty’s part; and that, monseigneur, may have its dangers. Your eminence is too skilful a politician not to know that, at this moment, the king does not possess a hundred and fifty thousand livres clear in his coffers.’

‘That is not my affair,’ said Mazarin, triumphantly; ‘that belongs to M. le Surintendant Fouquet, whose accounts I gave you to verify some months ago.’

Colbert bit his lips at the name of Fouquet. ‘His majesty,’ said he, between his teeth, ‘has no money but that which M. Fouquet collects: your money, monseigneur, would afford him a delicious banquet.’

‘Well, but I am not the superintendent of his majesty’s finances—I have my purse—surely I would do much for his majesty’s welfare—some legacy—but I cannot disappoint my family.’

‘The legacy of a part would dishonour you and offend the king. Leaving a part to his majesty, is to avow that that part has inspired you with doubts as to the lawfulness of the means of acquisition.’

‘Monsieur Colbert!’

‘I thought your eminence did me the honour to ask my advice?’

‘Yes, but you are ignorant of the principal details of the question.’

‘I am ignorant of nothing, my lord; during ten years, all the columns of figures which are found in France, have passed into review before me; and if I have painfully nailed them into my brain, they are there now so well riveted, that, from the office of M. Letellier, who is sober, to the little secret

Chapter XLV

Confession of a Man of Wealth



HE Theatin entered deliberately, without being too much astonished at the noise and agitation which anxiety for the cardinal’s health had raised in his household. ‘Come in, my reverend father,’ said Mazarin, after a last look at the ruelle, ‘come in and console me.’

‘That is my duty, my lord,’ replied the Theatin.

‘Begin by sitting down, and making yourself comfortable, for I am going to begin with a general confession; you will afterwards give me a good absolution, and I shall believe myself more tranquil.’

‘My lord,’ said the father, ‘you are not so ill as to make a general confession urgent—and it will be very fatiguing—take care.’

‘You suspect, then, that it may be long, father?’

‘How can I think it otherwise, when a man has lived so completely as your eminence has done?’

‘Ah! that is true!—yes—the recital may be long.’

‘The mercy of God is great,’ snuffed the Theatin.

‘Stop,’ said Mazarin; ‘there I begin to terrify myself with having allowed so many things to pass which the Lord might reprove.’

‘Is that not always so?’ said the Theatin naively, removing further from the lamp his thin pointed face, like that of a mole. ‘Sinners are so forgetful beforehand, and scrupulous when it is too late.’

largesses of M. Fouquet, who is prodigal, I could recite, figure by figure, all the money that is spent in France from Marseilles to Cherbourg.’

‘Then, you would have me throw all my money into the coffers of the king!’ cried Mazarin, ironically; and from whom, at the same time the gout forced painful moans. ‘Surely the king would reproach me with nothing, but he would laugh at me, while squandering my millions, and with good reason.’

‘Your eminence has misunderstood me. I did not, the least in the world, pretend that his majesty ought to spend your money.’

‘You said so, clearly, it seems to me, when you advised me to give it to him.’

‘Ah,’ replied Colbert, ‘that is because your eminence, absorbed as you are by your disease, entirely loses sight of the character of Louis XIV’

‘How so?’

‘That character, if I may venture to express myself thus, resembles that which my lord confessed just now to the Theatin.’

‘Go on—that is?’

‘Pride! Pardon me, my lord, haughtiness, nobleness; kings have no pride, that is a human passion.’

‘Pride,—yes, you are right. Next?’

‘Well, my lord, if I have divined rightly, your eminence has but to give all your money to the king, and that immediately.’

‘But for what?’ said Mazarin, quite bewildered.

‘Because the king will not accept of the whole.’

‘What, and he a young man, and devoured by ambition?’

‘Just so.’

‘A young man who is anxious for my death—’

‘My lord!’

‘To inherit, yes, Colbert, yes, he is anxious for my death, in order to inherit. Triple fool that I am! I would prevent him!’

‘Exactly: if the donation were made in a certain form he would refuse it.’

‘Well; but how?’

‘That is plain enough. A young man who has yet done nothing—who burns to distinguish himself—who burns to reign alone, will never take anything ready built, he will construct for himself. This prince,

monseigneur, will never be content with the Palais Royal, which M. de Richelieu left him, nor with the Palais Mazarin, which you have had so superbly constructed, nor with the Louvre, which his ancestors inhabited; nor with St Germain, where he was born. All that does not proceed from himself, I predict, he will disdain.'

'And you will guarantee, that if I give my forty millions to the king—'
'Saying certain things to him at the same time, I guarantee he will refuse them.'

'But those things—what are they?'

'I will write them, if my lord will have the goodness to dictate them.'

'Well, but, after all, what advantage will that be to me?'

'An enormous one. Nobody will afterwards be able to accuse your eminence of that unjust avarice with which pamphleteers have reproached the most brilliant mind of the present age.'

'You are right, Colbert, you are right; go, and seek the king, on my part, and take him my will.'

'Your donation, my lord.'

'But, if he should accept it; if he should even think of accepting it!'

'Then there would remain thirteen millions for your family; and that is a good round sum.'

'But then you would be either a fool or a traitor.'

'And I am neither the one nor the other, my lord. You appear to be much afraid that the king will accept; you have a deal more reason to fear that he will not accept.'

'But, see you, if he does not accept, I should like to guarantee my thirteen reserved millions to him—yes, I will do so—yes. But my pains are returning, I shall faint. I am very, very ill, Colbert; I am near my end!'

Colbert started. The cardinal was indeed very ill; large drops of sweat flowed down upon his bed of agony, and the frightful pallor of a face streaming with water was a spectacle which the most hardened practitioner could not have beheld without much compassion. Colbert was, without doubt, very much affected, for he quitted the chamber, calling Bernouin to attend to the dying man, and went into the corridor. There, walking about with a meditative expression, which almost gave nobility to his vulgar head, his shoulders thrown up, his neck stretched out, his lips half open, to give vent to unconnected fragments of incoherent thoughts,

'I mean,' said Colbert, 'that besides those forty millions, five hundred and sixty thousand, two hundred livres, nine cents, eight farthings, there are thirteen millions that are not known.'

'Ouf!' sighed Mazarin, 'what a man!'

At this moment, the head of Bernouin appeared through the embrasure of the door.

'What is it?' asked Mazarin, 'and why do you disturb me?'

'The Theatin father, your eminence's director, was sent for this evening; and he cannot come again to my lord till after to-morrow.'

Mazarin looked at Colbert, who rose and took his hat, saying: 'I shall come again, my lord.'

Mazarin hesitated. 'No, no,' said he; 'I have as much business to transact with you as with him. Besides, you are my other confessor—and what I have to say to one the other may hear. Remain where you are, Colbert.'

'But my lord, if there be no secret of penitence, will the director consent to my being here?'

'Do not trouble yourself about that; come into the ruelle.'

'I can wait outside, monseigneur.'

'No, no, it will do you good to hear the confession of a rich man.'

Colbert bowed and went into the ruelle.

'Introduce the Theatin father,' said Mazarin, closing the curtains.

He accompanied this restitution with a most severe reprimand, during which Colbert contented himself with examining, feeling, even smelling, as it were, the paper, the characters, and the signature, neither more nor less than if he had to deal with the greatest forger in the kingdom. Mazarin behaved still more rudely to him, but Colbert, still impassible, having obtained a certainty that the letter was the true one, went off as if he had been deaf. This conduct obtained for him afterwards the post of Joubert; for Mazarin, instead of bearing malice, admired him, and was desirous of attaching so much fidelity to himself.

It may be judged by this single anecdote, what the character of Colbert was. Events, developing themselves, by degrees allowed all the powers of his mind to act freely. Colbert was not long in insinuating himself to the good graces of the cardinal: he became even indispensable to him. The clerk was acquainted with all his accounts without the cardinal's ever having spoken to him about them. This secret between them was a powerful tie, and this was why, when about to appear before the Master of another world, Mazarin was desirous of taking good counsel in disposing the wealth he was so unwillingly obliged to leave in this world. After the visit of Guenaud, he therefore sent for Colbert, desired him to sit down, and said to him: 'Let us converse, Monsieur Colbert, and seriously, for I am very ill, and I may chance to die.'

'Man is mortal,' replied Colbert.

'I have always remembered that, M. Colbert, and I have worked with that end in view. You know that I have amassed a little wealth.'

'I know you have, monseigneur.'

'At how much do you estimate, as near as you can, the amount of this wealth, M. Colbert?'

'At forty millions, five hundred and sixty thousand, two hundred livres, nine cents, eight farthings,' replied Colbert.

The cardinal heaved a deep sigh, and looked at Colbert with wonder, but he allowed a smile to steal across his lips.

'Known money,' added Colbert, in reply to that smile.

The cardinal gave quite a start in bed. 'What do you mean by that?' said he.

he lashed up his courage to the pitch of the undertaking contemplated, whilst within ten paces of him, separated only by a wall, his master was being stifled by anguish which drew from him lamentable cries, thinking no more of the treasures of the earth, or of the joys of Paradise, but much of all the horrors of hell. Whilst burning-hot napkins, physic, revulsives, and Guenaud, who was recalled, were performing their functions with increased activity, Colbert, holding his great head in both his hands, to compress within it the fever of the projects engendered by the brain, was meditating the tenor of the donation he would make Mazarin write, at the first hour of respite his disease should afford him. It would appear as if all the cries of the cardinal, and all the attacks of death upon this representative of the past, were stimulants for the genius of this thinker with the bushy eyebrows, who was turning already towards the rising sun of a regenerated society. Colbert resumed his place at Mazarin's pillow at the first interval of pain, and persuaded him to dictate a donation thus conceived.

About to appear before God, the Master of mankind, I beg the king, who was my master on earth, to resume the wealth which his bounty has bestowed upon me, and which my family would be happy to see pass into such illustrious hands. The particulars of my property will be found—they are drawn up—at the first requisition of his majesty, or at the last sigh of his most devoted servant,

JULES, CARDINAL DE MAZARIN.

The cardinal sighed heavily as he signed this; Colbert sealed the packet, and carried it immediately to the Louvre, whither the king had returned. He then went back to his own home, rubbing his hands with the confidence of workman who has done a good day's work.

then that letter itself. Mazarin coloured greatly whilst reading Anne of Austria's letter, gave Colbert a gracious smile and dismissed him.

'When shall I have the answer, monseigneur?'

'To-morrow,'

'To-morrow morning?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

The clerk turned upon his heel, after making his very best bow. The next day he was at his post at seven o'clock. Mazarin made him wait till ten. He remained patiently in the ante-chamber; his turn having come, he entered; Mazarin gave him a sealed packet. On the envelope of this packet were these words:—Monsieur Michel Letellier, etc. Colbert looked at the packet with much attention; the cardinal put on a pleasant countenance and pushed him towards the door.

'And the letter of the queen-mother, my lord?' asked Colbert.

'It is in with the rest, in the packet,' said Mazarin.

'Oh! very well,' replied Colbert; and placing his hat between his knees, he began to unseal the packet.

Mazarin uttered a cry. 'What are you doing?' said he, angrily.

'I am unsealing the packet, my lord.'

'You mistrust me, then, master pedant, do you? Did any one ever see such impertinence?'

'Oh! my lord, do not be angry with me! It is certainly not your eminence's word I place in doubt, God forbid!'

'What then?'

'It is the carefulness of your chancery, my lord. What is a letter? A rag. May not a rag be forgotten? And look, my lord, look if I was not right. Your clerks have forgotten the rag; the letter is not in the packet.'

'You are an insolent fellow, and you have not looked,' cried Mazarin, very angrily; 'begone and wait my pleasure.' Whilst saying these words, with perfectly Italian subtlety he snatched the packet from the hands of Colbert, and re-entered his apartments.

But this anger could not last so long as to be replaced in time by reason. Mazarin, every morning, on opening his closet door, found the figure of Colbert like a sentinel behind the bench, and this disagreeable figure never failed to ask him humbly, but with tenacity, for the queen-mother's letter. Mazarin could hold out no longer, and was obliged to give it up.

in Lyons to a merchant, whom he had quitted to come to Paris in the office of a Châtelet procureur named Biterne. It was here he learned the art of drawing up an account, and the much more valuable one of complicating it.

This stiffness of manner in Colbert had been of great service to him; it is so true that Fortune, when she has a caprice, resembles those women of antiquity, who, when they had a fancy, were disgusted by no physical or moral defects in either men or things. Colbert, placed with Michel Letellier, secretary of state in 1648, by his cousin Colbert, Seigneur de Saint-Renange, who protected him, received one day from the minister a commission for Cardinal Mazarin. His eminence was then in the enjoyment of flourishing health, and the bad years of the Fronde had not yet counted triple and quadruple for him. He was at Sedan, very much annoyed at a court intrigue in which Anne of Austria seemed inclined to desert his cause.

Of this intrigue Letellier held the thread. He had just received a letter from Anne of Austria, a letter very valuable to him, and strongly promising Mazarin; but, as he already played the double part which served him so well, and by which he always managed two enemies so as to draw advantage from both, either by embroiling them more and more or by reconciling them, Michel Letellier wished to send Anne of Austria's letter to Mazarin, in order that he might be acquainted with it, and consequently pleased with his having so willingly rendered him a service. To send the letter was an easy matter; to recover it again, after having communicated it, that was the difficulty. Letellier cast his eyes around him, and seeing the black and meager clerk with the scowling brow, scribbling away in his office, he preferred him to the best gendarme for the execution of this design.

Colbert was commanded to set out for Sedan, with positive orders to carry the letter to Mazarin, and bring it back to Letellier. He listened to his orders with scrupulous attention, required the instructions to be repeated twice, and was particular in learning whether the bringing back was as necessary as the communicating; and Letellier replied sternly, 'More necessary.' Then he set out, traveled like a courier, without any care for his body, and placed in the hands of Mazarin, first a letter from Letellier, which announced to the cardinal the sending of the precious letter, and

Chapter XLVII

How Anne of Austria Gave One Piece of Advice to Louis XIV



HE news of the extreme illness of the cardinal had already spread, and attracted at least as much attention among the people of the Louvre as the news of the marriage of Monsieur, the king's brother, which had already been announced as an official fact. Scarcely had Louis XIV returned home, with his thoughts fully occupied with the various things he had seen and heard in the course of the evening, when an usher announced that the same crowd of courtiers who, in the morning, had thronged his lever, presented themselves again at his coucher, a remarkable piece of respect which, during the reign of the cardinal, the court, not very discreet in its performance, had accorded to the minister, without caring about displeasing the king.

But the minister had had, as we have said, an alarming attack of gout, and the tide of flattery was mounting towards the throne. Courtiers have a marvellous instinct in scenting the turn of events; courtiers possess a supreme kind of science; they are diplomats in throwing light upon the unravelling of complicated intrigues, captains in divining the issue of battles, and physicians in curing the sick. Louis XIV, to whom his mother had taught this axiom, together with many others, understood at once that the cardinal must be very ill.

Scarcely had Anne of Austria conducted the young queen to her apartments and taken from her brow the head-dress of ceremony, when she

went to see her son in his cabinet, where, alone, melancholy, and depressed, he was indulging, as if to exercise his will, in one of those terrible inward passions—king's passions—which create events when they break out, and with Louis XIV, thanks to his astonishing command over himself, became such benign tempests, that his most violent, his only passion, that which Saint Simon mentions with astonishment, was that famous fit of anger which he exhibited fifty years later, on the occasion of a little concealment of the Duc de Maine's, and which had for result a shower of blows inflicted with a cane upon the back of a poor valet who had stolen a biscuit. The young king then was, as we have seen, a prey to a double excitement; and he said to himself as he looked in a glass, 'O king!—king by name, and not in fact;—phantom, vain phantom art thou!—inert statue, which has no other power than that of provoking salutations from courtiers, when wilt thou be able to raise thy velvet arm, or clench thy silken hand? when wilt thou be able to open, for any purpose but to sigh, or smile, lips condemned to the motionless stupidity of the marbles in thy gallery?'

Then, passing his hand over his brow, and feeling the want of air, he approached a window, and looking down, saw below some horsemen talking together, and groups of timid observers. These horsemen were a fraction of the watch: the groups were busy portions of the people, to whom a king is always a curious thing, the same as a rhinoceros, a crocodile, or a serpent. He struck his brow with his open hand, crying,—'King of France! what a title! People of France! what a heap of creatures! I have just returned to my Louvre; my horses, just unharnessed, are still smoking, and I have created interest enough to induce scarcely twenty persons to look at me as I passed. Twenty! what do I say? no; there were not twenty anxious to see the king of France. There are not even ten archers to guard my palace of residence: archers, people, guards, all are at the Palais Royal! Why, my good God! have not I, the king, the right to ask of you all that?'

'Because,' said a voice, replying to his, and which sounded from the other side of the door of the cabinet, 'because at the Palais Royal lies all the gold,—that is to say, all the power of him who desires to reign.'

Louis turned round sharply. The voice which had pronounced these words was that of Anne of Austria. The king started, and advanced towards her. 'I hope,' said he, 'your majesty has paid no attention to the

Chapter XLIV

Colbert



COLBERT was not far off. During the whole evening he had remained in one of the corridors, chatting with Bernouin and Brienne, and commenting, with the ordinary skill of people of court, upon the news which developed like air-bubbles upon the water, on the surface of each event. It is doubtless time to trace, in a few words, one of the most interesting portraits of the age, and to trace it with as much truth, perhaps, as contemporary painters have been able to do. Colbert was a man in whom the historian and the moralist have an equal right.

He was thirteen years older than Louis XIV, his future master. Of middle height, rather lean than otherwise, he had deep-set eyes, a mean appearance, his hair was coarse, black and thin, which, say the biographers of his time, made him take early to the skull-cap. A look of severity, of harshness even, a sort of stiffness, which, with inferiors, was pride, with superiors an affectation of superior virtue; a surly cast of countenance upon all occasions, even when looking at himself in a glass alone—such is the exterior of his personage. As to the moral part of his character, the depth of his talent for accounts, and his ingenuity in making sterility itself productive, were much boasted of. Colbert had formed the idea of forcing governors of frontier places to feed the garrisons without pay, with what they drew from contributions. Such a valuable quality made Mazarin think of replacing Joubert, his intendant, who had recently died, by M. Colbert, who had such skill in nibbling down allowances. Colbert by degrees crept into court, notwithstanding his lowly birth, for he was the son of a man who sold wine as his father had done, but who afterwards sold cloth, and then silk stuffs. Colbert, destined for trade, had been clerk